

Delicacies for a Privileged Class in a Risk Society: The Chinese Communist Party's Special Supplies Food System

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This paper discusses the history and operation of the tegong (special supplies) system for foodstuffs operated by the Chinese Communist Party (CCP). The system has been in existence since the Yan'an period and is still being practiced today. It was originally introduced to deal with China's shortage economy during the era of Mao Zedong. Nowadays, the issue of food safety has made China a risk society, making it necessary for the CCP to provide its privileged class with food that is safe for consumption. We distinguish two categories of food supplies in terms of their operation: dedicated supplies for special needs and routine tegong. In addition, we believe that an alliance relationship between the government and food enterprises has emerged within the tegong system, with government officials and businesses colluding to their mutual benefit and profit. The paper concludes that the continuation of the tegong system signifies the persistence of a high degree of social inequality in modern-day China.

KEYWORDS: Food safety; privileged class; risk society; social inequality; *tegong*.

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In recent years, food safety issues have become a national concern in China (Yang, 2013). Although government departments have tried to strengthen food safety regulations (Liu *et al.*, 2013; Tam & Yang, 2005), these efforts have not achieved any significant outcome. Toxic food products continue to be available throughout China, compounding the food safety issue.¹ In an attempt to minimize potential health hazards, the Chinese Communist Party (CCP) has provided its privileged class with *tegong* (特供, special supplies of food) (Yan, 2012, p. 723). The *tegong* system was adopted from the Soviet Union, which from its inception provided its government officials with daily necessities according to their respective grades. The higher the position, the better the benefits received (O'Clery, 2011, pp. 34–35).² The CCP implemented a *tegong* system based on the Soviet model as early as the Yan'an period, providing its cadres with household items of better quality. Some Party members wrote papers criticizing the practice, stating that it violated the ideology of equality embodied in Marxism (Chen, 2011, p. 156). Despite these protests, however, the system continued to develop in the country and it persists to this day.³

Tegong is a sensitive and confidential subject for the CCP, and the Party is reluctant to allow too much information about it to leak out because it serves an exclusive elite and can spark public resentment. To date, the farms and food enterprises responsible for *tegong* have mostly refused requests for media interviews (“Bufen Jiguan”, 2010), so the outside world has limited knowledge of how the system operates. Indeed, in 2011, the

¹For a discussion of the management of food safety in China, see Wilson (2008, pp. 314–318), Wu and Zhu (2015, pp. 84–88), and Yasuda (2015).

²The Soviet Union and other communist countries often established *tegong* stores for the privileged class. However, under Mikhail Gorbachev's rule, the Soviet Union gradually eliminated the *tegong* system, thus leading to dissatisfaction amongst the privileged class. The cadres' dissatisfaction contributed toward the Soviet Union's collapse. This lesson from the Soviet Union may have led to the CCP's resolute defense of the *tegong* system, leading to exchange of goods for cadres' loyalty to the Party.

³Although a similar system existed prior to 1960, the official lexicon did not contain the term *tegong* (特供). It was first mentioned in a 1960 document which stated that designated persons are entitled to food supplies based on special needs (特需供應, *texu gongying*), a term abbreviated to *tegong* (CCP Central Committee, 1960).

secretary of the Guangdong Party Committee, Wang Yang (汪洋), was quoted as saying, “The issue of food safety is important for the development of society. To be honest, the officials here do not have any special supplies. We buy and eat the same food as everyone else. We are also personally affected [by the food safety issue]” (Chinese News Network, 2011).

However, research reveals that the *tegong* system still exists in modern-day China, and its mode of operation has become more institutionalized. Furthermore, the *tegong* system highlights the continued existence of inequality in Chinese society, as well as the special treatment enjoyed by the privileged class, including individuals engaged in important tasks and senior cadres. Some scholars believe that since the beginning of the era of economic reform and opening up, China has gradually moved from an economic model of redistribution to a market economy. As a consequence of this, it is claimed, the economic status of the privileged class is no higher than that of ordinary people (Nee, 1989). However, this argument has been challenged by many other scholars who argue from the perspective of persistence of power and hold that even after the reform and opening up, the political elite has continued to employ various means to maintain its superior economic status (Bian & Logan, 1996).

Our study also confirms the persistence of power argument in so far as the Chinese political elite is concerned. We find that the privileged class still enjoys absolute privilege with respect to food supplies; however, one of China’s unique aspects is that the CCP, through a national system, completely and systematically provides the privileged class with better daily life commodities. Government agencies make use of their huge administrative resources and enter into cooperative relationships with certain manufacturers, forming a tight benefits chain. Government agencies provide the food manufacturers with various benefits in exchange for the provision of high-quality food ingredients at low prices. Manufacturers also enjoy the surreptitious support of the government during the *tegong* process. In addition, they gain a good business reputation, which helps them with their marketing and promotion efforts. This phenomenon is a reflection of the close alliance that has been formed between the government and food enterprises in modern-day China. The *tegong* system has

also encouraged certain malpractices that will be discussed in the final section of this paper.

Who Gets to Enjoy *Tegong*? Two Privileged Classes in China Under the CCP

The CCP's *tegong* system is a huge logistical setup. The items it encompasses include food, clothing, and even porcelain ware (Du, 2011). Given the limited space available here, this paper will only discuss *tegong* in relation to food items. Food has always played an important role in the CCP's political operations. When Mao Zedong (毛澤東) issued his call for revolution, his slogan was "supplying food for the people is the most important mission" (*chifan enti zuida*, 吃飯問題最大), and he declared that the CCP would solve the masses' food problems (Farquhar, 2002, pp. 124–128). Ironically, it was CCP cadres who ended up becoming members of the inner circle and enjoying *tegong* privileges.

In a certain sense, the items supplied through *tegong* are a type of exclusive goods (Sunstein & Ullmann-Margalit, 2001, p. 134). In this paper, in order to be defined as *tegong*, foodstuffs must fulfill three conditions: (1) they must contain high-quality food ingredients supplied by special production bases, (2) they must be supplied for consumption by members of designated privileged classes,⁴ and (3) they must be offered to these classes at a discounted price, or even free of charge.

We have classified the two privileged classes that get to enjoy *tegong* as those classified by work and those distinguished by rank. The former group consists of persons who are granted *tegong* because they are responsible for carrying out important tasks. They are not necessarily senior cadres, but can be non-officials or foreigners. The latter group are senior cadres who have attained a specific administrative rank. During the Mao

⁴This definition can also help differentiate *tegong* from the concept of social welfare. Although both are selective forms of resource subsidies, the targeted beneficiaries of the former are the privileged classes, while beneficiaries of the latter tend to be ordinary members of the public and disadvantaged groups.

era, all state and ministerial-level cadres qualified for better *tegong*.⁵ In the shortage economy that existed at that time,⁶ *tegong* enabled the regime to guarantee the livelihoods of these two important groups of people.

The task-oriented group of *tegong* recipients comprises two categories. The first includes important non-government personnel (such as researchers responsible for national defense technologies or athletes). Since their achievements are considered to be a matter of national pride and honor, they are provided with better living conditions than the general public to boost their morale. An example of this dates from the time of the development of the Chinese atomic bomb in the 1960s. Living conditions throughout China were dire, but Zhou Enlai (周恩來) provided scientists involved in the project with valuable food items, such as ham (Deng, 2013, p. 72). Athletes were also guaranteed a superior diet through *tegong*. During the Mao era, outstanding athletes were even granted additional rations of meat (Gao, 2004, p. 17).

The second task-oriented category is foreigners, especially personnel from other countries stationed in China. The Chinese government has provided these expatriates with *tegong* in an effort to win them over by demonstrating the superiority of socialism. In 1964, the CCP set up the Friendship Store (友誼商店, *youyi shangdian*) in Beijing for the purpose of promoting friendship with foreign countries and to provide foreigners based in China with *tegong* supplies. Special goods that were highly valued at that time included jams, chocolates, wines, and leather shoes (“Beijing *youyi shangdian*”, 2009).

Within the class privileged on account of their rank, the CCP provided better-quality *tegong* to state- and ministerial-level leaders during the Mao era. It was mandatory for kitchen staff and chefs in charge of preparing food and beverages consumed by state-level leaders to use only *tegong* ingredients, and it was forbidden to use ingredients bought from outside sources. This was to ensure cadres’ food safety (Zhang, 2011b). The ingredients

⁵The CCP has inherited the Soviet system of *nomenklatura*, which provides for different degrees of privilege for cadres at different levels (Burns, 1987).

⁶For a discussion on the “shortage economy,” see Kornai (1992, p. 233).

used to prepare these dishes were supposed to be fresh and safe and were sourced from areas of the country dedicated to their production (Wu, 2009). During the Mao era, the Xiangshan Farm (香山農場) was set up as a production base for *tegong* exclusively for state leaders. The farm was under the jurisdiction of the General Office of the CCP Central Committee. Off-season fruit was grown there to cater for Mao's tastes and to allow him to consume fruit whenever he wished (Zhang, 2011a).

The other *tegong* center for state-level leaders was located on the fourth floor of the Beijing Department Store.⁷ This center was originally set up to provide logistical support for the Extended Meeting of the CCP held in May 1960, but it continued to serve state leaders exclusively until the Cultural Revolution. There, cadres were able to purchase *tegong* goods at low prices, including fine fabrics, tobacco products, food items, and local specialties from all over the country. Cadres were also able to make purchases there on credit. The general public were allowed to purchase ordinary goods on the first three floors of the department store, but were not permitted to access the fourth floor. Since the *tegong* center was located in Room 7, it was given the nickname "Dark No. 7" (黑七號, *hei qi hao*) during the Cultural Revolution, implying that it was dedicated to serving an elite and privileged class (Miao & Dou, 2008).

During the Mao era, the CCP established a number of agencies in charge of the provision of *tegong* to cadres at ministerial level and above (including state-level leaders). In the early days of nation building, the CCP established the *tegong* system under the jurisdiction of the Ministry of Public Security (MPS) to maintain the quality of meals served to cadres. The Second Commerce Bureau (SCB, 第二商業局, *dier shangye ju*) of the Beijing Municipal Government was set up in 1955, and in 1956 it assumed responsibility for providing *tegong* to cadres at ministerial level and above. Workers responsible for the production of *tegong* supplies had to undergo special

⁷The Beijing Department Store was built in 1955 in Beijing's Wangfujing (王府井) Street. It was one of the most important state-owned enterprises at that time. After China's reform and opening up, the policy was to separate business enterprises from the government. Hence, the store was transformed and renamed the Wangfujing Department Store. It was no longer responsible for providing *tegong* to cadres.

screening to confirm their political loyalty before being hired. By 1978, the SCB had established several major *tegong* centers in Beijing.

Another agency was the Department for the Special Supply of Everyday Goods and Materials for CCP Leaders (中央領導生活物資特別供應處, *Zhongyang lingdao shenghuo wuzi tebie gongying chu*). It provided *tegong* only to cadres at vice-ministerial level and above and was located at No. 34, Donghuamen Street (東華門大街, *donghuamen dajie*). To maintain confidentiality, the sign at the entrance to the department simply stated “No. 34 Supplies Department” (34 號供應部, *sanshisi hao gongying bu*), while CCP insiders simply called it “No. 34.” The building was previously occupied by the Foodstuffs Security Office of the MPS, which was an exclusive unit used by the CCP to provide its leaders with food supplies during the early 1950s (Gao, 2004, p. 16). The goods sold at No. 34 included not only top-quality, domestically produced products but also imported goods, such as branded electrical appliances, watches, perfume, wine, food items, jewelry, and ornaments (Qin, 2013). This department still exists today but has since been renamed the Beijing Eastern Friendship Foodstuffs Delivery Company (BEFF, 北京市東方友誼食品配送公司, *Beijing shi dongfang youyi shipin peisong gongsi*).

The shortage economy during the Mao era meant that even daily necessities were in short supply. The CCP primarily allowed two special classes — task- and rank-oriented — to own daily necessities. Seen from a modern-day perspective, *tegong* items at that time seem to be quite ordinary. However, the provision of these necessities to Party and government cadres, as well as important foreign personnel and VIPs, was considered to be a crucial political mission at that time.

Dealing with a Risk Society after the 1980s: Two Categories of *Tegong*

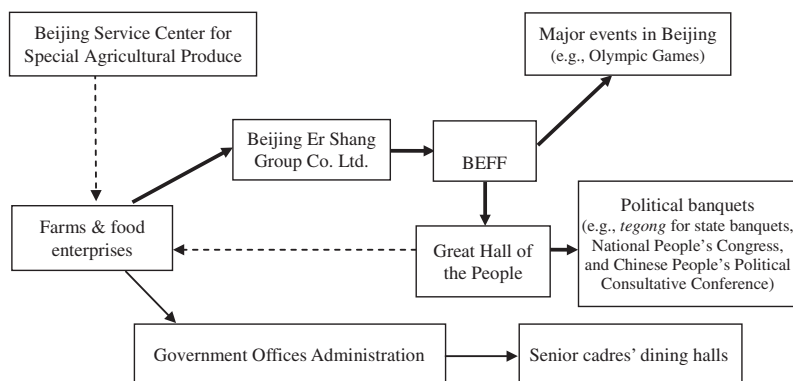
When China’s economic development began to take off after the launch of the reform and opening-up program, the shortage economy came

to an end. In order to ease public resentment over the *tegong* system, the CCP announced in an official document in 1989 that special supplies of food for designated groups or senior cadres would be terminated (CCP Central Committee, 1989). However, this policy was not actually carried out because of the dilemmas created by the risk society. In an effort to reduce costs and maximize profits, many food manufacturers engaged in producing goods using new technologies (e.g., genetic modification and growth hormones) or illegal means (e.g., using recycled cooking oil).⁸ As food safety became a new cause for concern, the provision of safe food for consumption by the privileged class became an important new political mission.

Tegong as it is currently operated can be divided into two main categories: dedicated supplies for special occasions (特需專供, *texu zhuangong*) and routine *tegong* (日常性特供, *richangxing tegong*). Similar to the selective standards applicable to the privileged class in the Mao era, dedicated supplies for special occasions and routine *tegong* were provided respectively to task- and rank-oriented groups. Examples of the former include National People's Congress (NPC) delegates, domestic and foreign guests attending state banquets, and athletes competing in major sporting events, such as the Beijing Olympics. It is for food safety reasons that the CCP provides them with *tegong* ingredients. The latter group comprises cadres at bureau level and above. The CCP has set up exclusive senior cadres' dining halls to provide them with tasty and healthy food and beverages.⁹ The operational structure of both types of *tegong* is shown in Figure 1.

⁸For a discussion on the risk society, see Beck (1992) and Giddens (1998, pp. 204–217).

⁹Only cadres at ministerial level and above were entitled to better *tegong* during the Mao era. However, during the post-Deng era, even bureau-level cadres have been able to enjoy top-class *tegong*. In the Jiang Zemin era, with the development of market economic reforms, the CCP was increasingly unable to inculcate Party cadres' loyalty either consciously or by using political education. Thus, the CCP focused on improving the cadres' lifestyle by enabling more of them to enjoy high quality goods and foodstuffs, thus causing them to remain loyal to the Party. This indicates that there has been no improvement in equality within Chinese society. Interview with a member of staff of an official canteen, Beijing, March 2, 2016.



Note: (1) Thick solid lines represent the flow of dedicated supplies for special occasions.
(2) Thin solid lines represent the flow of routine *tegong*.
(3) Dotted lines represent quality control.

Figure 1. Operational flow of the *tegong* system.

The first category of *tegong* — dedicated supplies for special occasions — caters for political banquets held in Beijing and for major events, and it is under the charge of the Beijing Er Shang Group Co. Ltd. (BESG, 北京二商集團有限責任公司, *Beijing ershang jituan youxian zeren gongsi*) and its subsidiary, the BEFF. The predecessor of the BESG was the SCB¹⁰ and that of the BEFF was the No. 34 Supplies Department. Although both companies have since started supplying food to the general public, they are still responsible for *tegong* within the Beijing municipality and continue to provide higher quality foodstuffs to individuals who carry out important work.

The BESG has contractual agreements with 13 food enterprises supplying meat, vegetables, fruit, tea, etc. to ensure an uninterrupted supply of high-quality ingredients. All the manufacturers and farms that have contracts with the BESG supply products of extremely high quality, such as the BESG's *tegong* pork, for example. Some of this meat is supplied by the

¹⁰When the CCP sought to strengthen the operation of the market in the 1990s, it restructured some government agencies into corporate enterprises. In 1997, as part of this process, the SCB was restructured into the BESG (Beijing Second Commercial Group, 2014).

Minghui (明慧) Pig Farm, which is based in the suburbs of Sanhe City (三河市), Hebei Province. This enterprise has invested a great deal of effort to ensure the quality of its pork. In 2006, when there was an outbreak of the porcine reproductive and respiratory syndrome (commonly known as blue-ear disease) in China, the farm did not use the free vaccines provided by the government. Instead, it imported expensive vaccines from overseas for its herd (Jiang, 2011). Another example is the Da Hong Men (大紅門) Meat Food Co. Ltd., which is also contracted to supply the BESS. This company has set up a dedicated *tegong* room where the temperature and environmental conditions are strictly controlled using costly equipment so as to ensure the proper execution of its *tegong* duties and the freshness of the meat it supplies (“Zhongguo shi quanli”, 2013).

The BEFF, another important unit in charge of the first category of *tegong*, specializes in the delivery and distribution of food ingredients to government agencies. Two types of supplies are extremely important, both of which have political significance. The first type is used for sporting events, such as the 2008 Beijing Olympic Games, for which the BEFF provided more than 1,500 categories of *tegong* foodstuffs for the athletes’ village (Zhou, 2008). Food safety was critical to the success of the Olympic Games and as a consequence China’s image in the outside world; therefore, the CCP mandated that all enterprises responsible for the *tegong* of food for this event fulfill their duties regardless of cost. An official from one of those food enterprises remarked, “It was a political mission. For such missions, costs are not an issue” (Zhang, 2007). Please see Figure 2 for the building of BEFF.

The other type of *tegong* for special occasions consists of ingredients for banquets hosted by the central government and its agencies, including state banquets. Since food safety for these events is essential, this form of *tegong* is also considered to be a political mission. The ballroom of the Great Hall of the People (人民大會堂, *renmin dahui tang*) is the usual location for such banquets. The BEFF delivers the requisite ingredients to the Great Hall’s management bureau, which then passes the ingredients to the ballroom for preparation and cooking.



Note: Left: Every day, trucks arrive at the main entrance of the BEFF with deliveries of the finest ingredients from various places for storage and subsequent distribution.

Right: The sign above the company's office building reads "Beijing Er Shang Group: Eastern Friendship Foodstuffs Delivery Company."

Source: Author's photographs, September 26, 2015.

Figure 2. The BEFF's main entrance and office building.

Upon receiving instructions to prepare a state banquet, the ballroom's staff first liaise with the Ministry of Foreign Affairs so they can find out the dietary preferences of the foreign guests and Chinese officials who will be attending, and what kinds of food to avoid serving. A draft menu is then prepared and sent to the Ministry of Foreign Affairs for approval (Rao & Wang, 2009). Once the ministry gives its approval, the BEFF delivers the ingredients for the dishes on the menu.

Great importance is accorded to food and beverages served to delegates of the NPC and the Chinese People's Political Consultative Conference (CPPCC). The BESS even deploys specialists to the various food production locations to ensure the safety and quality of ingredients served throughout the duration of the two meetings (Wang, 2012a).

The second category of *tegong* — routine *tegong* — consists of the provision of food for senior cadres at bureau level and above.¹¹ This is the responsibility of logistics units, Government Offices Administrations (GOAs, 機關事務管理局, *jiguan shiwu guanli ju*), and unit canteens. Each government agency at county level and above has a GOA.¹² For

¹¹It appears that for central or regional government cadres, only those at the bureau level or above can obtain such *tegong*.

¹²Interview with a reporter of the CCP's official journal, Beijing, July 4, 2015.

example, the GOA of the State Council oversees all the logistics, services, and management matters concerning state agencies (The GOA of the State Council, 2013). The GOAs are responsible for the procurement of ingredients supplied to the unit canteens. Of course, not all high-level cadres eat only in canteens. They sometimes obtain luxury or even illegal foodstuffs through their personal secretaries.¹³ These, however, are unofficial channels and beyond the scope of this paper; we shall thus continue to understand the senior cadres' routine *tegong* through a study of the functions of the canteens.

The canteen embodies all the characteristics of the CCP's unit system.¹⁴ All units must provide their cadres and staff with daily necessities, including daily meals. The unit canteens are segregated according to grade and comprise a common dining hall (for staff and low-level cadres) and a senior cadres' dining hall. Although unit canteens provide meals at discounted prices, we feel that meals served in common dining halls should not be treated as a form of *tegong* because the ingredients used are probably sourced from commercial markets rather than special production bases. On the other hand, the meals served in senior cadres' dining halls better fit the definition of *tegong*.

Cadres at bureau level and above enjoy larger discounts and more sumptuous food in the exclusive senior cadres' dining halls. Those at ministerial level and above get their meals completely free of charge (Wang, 2012a). These dining halls are known to insiders as "small kitchens" (小灶, *xiaozao*), while the common dining halls are called "large kitchens" (大灶, *dazao*). Some of the senior cadres' dining halls are beautifully appointed and located in secluded areas. They look more like private reception halls than canteens. The food ingredients used there are of top quality and supplied by designated production bases. The meals are

¹³A cadre working in Shanghai told the author that he had seen other cadres obtain meat from the Yangtze river dolphin (*Lipotes vexillifer*) to eat. These animals live in the Yangtze watershed region and are a severely endangered species. Interview with a CCP cadre, Shanghai, February 21, 2015.

¹⁴For related discussions on China's unit system, please refer to Walder (1986, pp. 59–67) and Lü & Perry (1997).

prepared by chefs hired from high-class hotels, and cadres are served by attractive waitresses.¹⁵

Production Bases for *Tegong*

Safe ingredients are provided by designated farms or related food enterprises regardless of the *tegong* category.¹⁶ Under China's food regulations, agricultural products are divided into four grades: organic; green, i.e., clean and unadulterated; pollution-free; and general. Farms and food enterprises responsible for *tegong* are involved in the production of the first three grades of agricultural products. The higher a cadre's position or the more important the task he/she is engaged in, the better the quality of *tegong*.¹⁷

The production process for organic products is completely natural and chemical-free. The production volume is low, but the quality is very high. For green products, small amounts of chemical pesticides and fertilizers are permitted, and their quality is just one notch below that of organic products. The requirements for pollution-free products are less stringent than those for the first two grades: the production environment only needs to be clean and pollution-free (Zhang, 2013). These products qualify as *tegong* foods. Higher-level cadres enjoy higher-quality foods owing to high production standards and better quality. The quality standards for general products are even more relaxed. These are mainly intended for consumption by the general public.

The CCP implements strict monitoring of food production bases to enhance the quality of *tegong* products. In 2002, the Ministry of

¹⁵Interview with a staff member in an official canteen, Beijing, February 26, 2016.

¹⁶For related discussions on how government agencies ensure food safety, please refer to Klein (2013, pp. 385–388).

¹⁷State-, ministerial-, and bureau-level cadres eat standard foods, such as rice, vegetables, and meat; however, these are produced at different places depending on their grade. Higher-level cadres receive higher-quality foodstuffs. For example, Jushan Farm products are only provided to state-level cadres. However, this paper cannot examine the specific differences in the foodstuffs of cadres across various levels due to insufficient data.

Agriculture (MOA) set up the Beijing Service Center for Special Agricultural Produce and formulated strict criteria for the assessment of *tegong* products. A *tegong* supplier's contract will be terminated immediately if it fails any of the critical control points (Lu, 2011). The ballroom of the Great Hall of the People, which is responsible for state and other political banquets, also monitors the quality of banquet ingredients. Cadres from the hall's management bureau personally carry out rigorous inspections at production bases for *tegong* ingredients. Quality inspectors wear white gloves and slide their hands over production machinery to see whether the gloves get soiled. They also check the air quality at the production bases and the way employees are treated (Hu, 2009).

Government agencies enter into contractual agreements with external parties to obtain *tegong* ingredients that can be supplied to their senior cadres' dining halls. Professor He Bing (何兵) of the China University of Political Science and Law has published a blog post in which he describes eating in the unit canteen during a visit to a government agency in one of China's western provinces in 2009. The canteen staff told him, "The food that we serve is safe for you to consume. It is all 'green food' [i.e., pure and unadulterated]." The post also mentions that several provincial government offices have production bases dedicated to the provision of *tegong* ingredients ("Bufen Jiguan", 2010).

Tegong ingredients may be produced by government or private farms. An example of the former is the Jushan State Farm (巨山農場, *jushan nongchang*), which is located in the suburbs of Beijing and has been an important production base supplying *tegong* to officials since the Mao era.¹⁸ Most of the ingredients of the meals prepared daily for state-level leaders are supplied by this farm. The farm has now been transferred to the Beijing Capital Agribusiness Group (首都農業集團公司, *shoudu nongye jituan gongsi*), which is under the Beijing Municipal Government.

¹⁸The predecessor of the Jushan State Farm was the Xiangshan Farm, which was established during the Mao era.

The farm occupies 1,353 acres of land. Trucks belonging to government departments and military units drive in and out regularly to collect fresh fruit and vegetables. These agricultural products are not sold commercially, so the outside world has very little knowledge of the farm. Even residents living in the vicinity do not know much about it, except that the vegetables grown there are for consumption by senior officials and the Standing Committee of the CCP Politburo. A reporter once tried to access the farm but was quickly blocked by security personnel. The latter stated that it was a special farm which outsiders were not permitted to visit. A member of the farm's staff told that reporter, "It is only necessary for you to understand one point: the vegetables grown here are the best in the whole of China!" (Wang, 2013).

The Jushan State Farm produces top-grade organic produce. Mr. Liu, an agriculture expert, was invited to visit the farm in 2001 and assist with the installation of production equipment. He published a blog post describing his personal experience there:

It was my first contact with the production methods of "special supplies" farms. [During the production process, the farm uses] fermented soybeans as fertilizers and spring water from Yuquan (玉泉) Mountain for irrigation.¹⁹ Chemical fertilizers and pesticides are not used at all. When we were installing the equipment, we drank milk that is supplied for consumption by the CCP's senior leaders and not sold commercially. That was a fantastic feeling. The farm is enclosed by high boundary walls and guarded by sentries. The head of that farm has an equivalent rank to that of a divisional commander.²⁰

Another example of a government-operated farm is the Beijing Customs' Vegetable Base and Country Club located in Beijing's Shunyi (順義) District, known to insiders as the Green House. This farm produces supplies exclusively for staff of the Beijing Customs. Occupying an area of approximately five acres, it is in a highly secluded location that is very difficult for outsiders to find. Natural organic fertilizers are used for all the

¹⁹Yuquan Mountain, located in Beijing's Haidian (海淀) District, is a scenic location where high-ranking officials and retired cadres live or hold meetings. It is not open to the public.

²⁰Divisional commander is a military rank equivalent to that of a county-level cadre. This paper was retrieved from "Tegong Nongchang" (2012).

agricultural products grown there. Trucks of the Beijing Customs arrive on Monday, Wednesday, and Friday mornings to load and then deliver huge quantities of vegetables (Lu, 2011).

Exclusive official farms are not necessarily owned by government departments. It is likely that many departments purchase high-quality foodstuffs from private farms as *tegong* for specific groups and senior cadres (normally at bureau level and above). One example is Beijing's Luohe (漯河) Pig Farm, which specializes in the provision of *tegong* pork. To improve the quality of the meat, the farm provides its herds with a good living environment, including the circulation of warm air during winter and cooling water sprays in summer. To prevent the spread of disease, the farm is not open to the public. When employees return from visits outside the farm, they are quarantined for three days. Only after it is confirmed that they do not have any symptoms of flu or fever are they allowed to enter the farm. In addition, each pig is given two eggs per day to improve the meat quality and rate of reproduction. Lactating sows can even enjoy fish soup (Zhang & Chang, 2015).

Another private farm breeding *tegong* pigs is in Xianyan (仙岩) Village, Zhejiang Province. The animals are not injected with growth hormones, so it can take as long as one year to rear each animal. The farm slaughters two pigs a day and the meat is distributed to various agencies in the province, including the departments of Land and Resources, Water Resources, and Agriculture (Xie & Shang, 2015).

In addition to providing government departments with food, some *tegong* production bases also welcome sightseers. The Beijing Anlilong (安利隆) Eco-Agricultural Tourism Resort has fruit and vegetable plots, chicken and duck farms, and fish ponds. The crops and other plants are grown naturally, and cockroaches are used to get rid of pests instead of chemical pesticides and insecticides. The resort provides *tegong* for the General Administration of Quality Supervision, Inspection and Quarantine (AQSIQ). To obtain ingredients, AQSIQ cadres pass a list of their requirements to the resort's staff. The general public can pay an admission

fee to visit the resort and even pick fruit and vegetables. However, prices for such services are high (Wang, 2012a).

Is There Such a Thing as a Free Lunch? The Alliance between the Government and Food Enterprises

The purpose of *tegong* nowadays is to reduce food safety risks for the privileged class. After decades of operation, a mutually-dependent benefits chain has formed between the government and food enterprises (farms and factories), leading to a close alliance relationship between the two parties. Although cooperation of this kind also exists in the West (Nestle, 2002, pp. 99–107), it seems to be more comprehensive and institutionalized in China. On the one hand, Chinese government agencies provide enterprises with subsidies or concessions to obtain high-quality ingredients at low prices, while on the other hand, food enterprises provide the government with cheap *tegong* to obtain covert backing from the government and to strengthen their brands, which contributes to product marketing.²¹ This still-developing relationship between the government and enterprises is depicted in Figure 3.

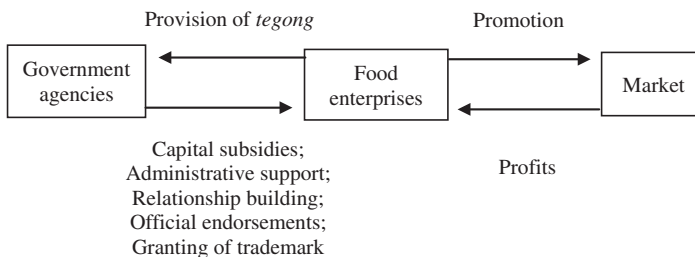


Figure 3. Alliance relationship between government and food enterprises in modern-day China.

²¹Many scholars have noted the benefits chain that links enterprises and the Chinese government, and how the two sides are integrated. For related literature, please refer to Dickson (2008) and Unger & Chan (2015).

These food enterprises provide government agencies (including the BESG, the Great Hall of the People, and GOAs) with high-quality ingredients at low prices, ensuring dedicated supplies for special occasions and, in the case of routine *tegong*, allowing unit canteens to offer meals at prices far below those of the market, thereby benefitting the privileged class who dine there (Wang, 2012b). In the case of *maotai* (茅臺, a spirit distilled from sorghum), for example, although the price at which the distillery sells the liquor to the government is a commercial secret, it must be fairly cheap and much lower than the market price of fine liquors (Zhou, 2012).

There is definitely no such thing as a free lunch. Food enterprises are willing to provide *tegong* at low prices for several reasons. The first is to obtain other forms of compensation from government agencies. Some of these agencies have control over funds of various kinds. For example, the MOA has substantial funds earmarked for upgrading agricultural facilities or improving the environment. It has the authority to decide which units and enterprises are granted these funds. When it requires a particular food enterprise to provide *tegong*, it can allow the enterprise to apply for these funds as a form of compensation for selling its products at a low price (Xie & Shang, 2015).

The second reason is to obtain covert administrative support from the government. Local governments have the authority to approve land development applications. In exchange for the provision of *tegong* to the local government, food enterprises can secure land use rights at low prices in order to expand their facilities. In addition, local governments have the power to grant enterprises compensatory tax breaks.²²

The third reason why enterprises are willing to provide cut-price *tegong* is so that they can build relationships with government leaders. Some enterprises specialize in the provision of top-grade ingredients to senior officials of government agencies and use that as a means to establish personal relationships with those officials. Such high-quality *tegong* items for senior officials used to be elaborately packaged in the past. However,

²²Interview with a reporter from the CCP's official journal, Beijing, August 2, 2015.

since Xi Jinping has launched an anti-corruption drive and is promoting integrity among officials, the packaging has been modified. Plain gift boxes are now used and the words “special supplies” are omitted.²³

The fourth reason for enterprises’ willingness to cooperate with this system is that leaders of government agencies can advertise or endorse certain *tegong* foods.²⁴ The *erguotou* (二鍋頭, a Chinese white liquor) produced by the Beijing Niulanshan (牛欄山) Distillery is the *tegong* liquor of choice for the Beijing Municipal Committee, the Beijing Municipal Government, the CCP’s Central Party School, and other agencies. The distillery invited Wang Gang (王剛), director of the General Office of the CCP Central Committee, to be its product spokesperson in 2007 (Qi, 2008).²⁵ Endorsement by officials makes the marketing and promotion of an enterprise’s products more effective.

The final reason is to obtain a *tegong* trademark. Several food enterprises that have contracts with the BESG have added the latter’s name to their trademarks. This is a great honor and indicates that these companies have earned the privilege of providing *tegong* to the privileged class. It is also an indication that their products are of high quality, which makes them more likely to be favored by consumers (Hu, 2005). Since China’s market economy began to flourish in the wake of the reform and opening up, a new bourgeoisie has arisen with a remarkable capacity for consumption. Among the *tegong* providers, only a minority (official enterprises or farms

²³Furthermore, as mentioned in footnote 13, leaders commonly obtained rare luxury foods through their personal secretaries. However, since Xi took charge, this phenomenon has become less common. Cadres can only obtain *tegong* through the channels shown in Figure 1 and most are regular foods produced at designated locations to guarantee their superior quality. Interview with a professor from the National Defense University of the People’s Liberation Army, Guangzhou, July 16, 2015.

²⁴Although on the whole the *tegong* system is becoming increasingly institutionalized, as the reviewer pointed out, suppliers and government officials’ methods of establishing relationships are in fact more informal than institutionalized. Although they represent a unique feature of Chinese culture, they may not be beneficial when operating the *tegong* system.

²⁵Owing to the sensitivity of the *tegong* system, the Chinese government still does not officially recognize its existence in an attempt to avoid the common people’s backlash. When officials mention *tegong* products, they avoid emphasizing the fact that they are a form of *tegong*. However, suppliers who provide *tegong* products often stress to the media that they produce these products to enhance their prestige.

supplying foodstuffs for state-level leaders) are banned from selling on the open market. Other *tegong* firms focus their sales and marketing efforts on the general public, particularly the new bourgeoisie, who are willing to pay extremely high prices for *tegong*-standard commodities.

It is clear from the discussion above that even though food enterprises provide *tegong* to government agencies at low prices, this carries with it certain marketing and promotion benefits. When the Yuexi (嶽西) green orchid tea produced in the village of Xianglu (香爐) in Anhui Province was selected by the Ministry of Foreign Affairs in 2010 to be offered to foreign guests to drink and as gifts, it soon became very famous and a bestseller (Jiao & Xu, 2012). In 2008, fruit from the city of Pingliang (平涼), Gansu Province, was selected as *tegong* for the Olympic Games. This generated substantial sales and revenue for the city. Subsequently, the fruit was successfully distributed for sale all over China and even exported to more than a dozen countries (Wang, 2011). The benefits chain linking government agencies and food enterprises not only allows the privileged class to obtain cheap *tegong* but also provides enterprises with huge returns.

Malpractices within the *Tegong* System

The *tegong* system is to some extent effective in ensuring the food safety of the privileged classes. However, it cannot be denied that this type of system gives rise to serious malpractices. In addition to its role in increasing inequality within Chinese society, it has had some side effects that should be examined further.

First, it is easy for corruption in the form of collusion between government and business to occur when government departments are selecting *tegong* enterprises or vendors and during the contract signing process. Although food enterprises must be approved by the MOA before qualifying to be *tegong* suppliers, the actual decision to offer a contract is often dependent on the enterprise's relationship with the leader of the relevant government department. Hence, food enterprises will try to secure contracts by enticing these officials with expensive gifts. However, this

kind of gift-giving sometimes goes beyond legal limits. For example, the Chinese believe in the medicinal properties of the bones and internal organs of ferocious wild beasts, and these are supplied to cadres through specialized businesses or farms. Some farms rear black bears and offer bear gallbladders to leaders of government departments on a private basis (Mi, 2010). The farms do this in order to secure *tegong* contracts, which will in turn help them market their other products.

Another form of malpractice occurs within the senior cadres' dining halls: auditors' reports on their funding have never been published and it is thought that they are hotbeds of corruption. The commonest form of corruption takes the form of collusion between government leaders and *tegong* vendors, with the latter providing *tegong* items (such as tobacco products and alcoholic beverages) for leaders' personal consumption and sending the invoices to the senior cadres' dining halls to be paid out of public funds.²⁶

In general, it is mandatory to provide tobacco products and liquor at official Chinese banquets. Hence, it is very common for unit canteens to order large quantities of these and have practically all the expenses written off. In many corruption cases, large quantities of extremely expensive tobacco products and alcohol were found in the homes of dismissed officials. Corrupt officials frequently help themselves to the public funds allocated to the senior cadres' dining halls.²⁷

Last, there have been many incidents of fake *tegong* items being sold at a premium on the open market. One example is *maotai*, which is an important type of *tegong* liquor. River water and red sorghum sourced from the town of Maotai in Guizhou Province are the essential ingredients of good tasting *maotai*, which rules out the possibility of large-scale production. Only government departments at provincial/ministerial level and above are permitted to purchase genuine *maotai*. However, many other products that claim to be *tegong* liquor from the Guizhou distillery are on the market (Zhou, 2012).

²⁶Interview with a member of staff of an official canteen, Beijing, February 26, 2016.

²⁷Interview with a professor from the National Defense University of the People's Liberation Army, Guangzhou, July 16, 2015.

The *tegong* system has created a form of consumer culture that values official status and endorsement. Given the mysterious aura that surrounds *tegong* items, it is no wonder that ordinary members of the public are eager to get hold of them. Some vendors even go to the extent of using slogans such as “bureau-level enjoyment” (*tingju ji de xiangshou*, 廳局級的享受) in their advertising (Xu, 2006). This kind of status-based consumer culture undoubtedly increases the likelihood that food enterprises will try to make a profit by producing fake *tegong* items.²⁸

Conclusion

This paper has discussed the history and current operation of the CCP’s *tegong* system. It is a system that was originally adopted from the Soviet Union but is still in existence today; in fact, it seems to have become more institutionalized. During the Mao era, *tegong* was based on the logic of the shortage economy. Today, *tegong* operations are maintained to deal with the food safety issue and to protect the privileged class in a risk society. Most of the units responsible for today’s *tegong* (such as the BESG, BEFF, and Jushan State Farm) were established under Mao. The *tegong* system’s evolution shows that the CCP is indeed a regime that has learned the lessons of history; it has retained past practices and systems, made improvements, and applied these to the governance of contemporary China (Heilmann & Perry, 2011, pp. 8–9).²⁹

²⁸Until now, the CCP seems unable to suppress this trend of fake *tegong* production. The primary reason is their unwillingness to publicly acknowledge the existence of the *tegong* system; thus, they cannot establish official regulations for it. If they were willing to do so, they could effectively strengthen the regulation of the *tegong* system.

²⁹The CCP might further think about or improve the continued use of the past *tegong* system in the present. The main problem with China’s authoritarian regime is that it is, unfortunately, probably incapable of solving the populace’s food safety problems. If the CCP refuses to follow democratic governance, then one practical choice might be to strengthen the supervision of the *tegong* system and its transparency by publishing an annual list of *tegong* suppliers and allowing *tegong* to become top brands for healthy food, thereby providing opportunities for better-off citizens to purchase these products.

In terms of the system's operation, we have distinguished between two categories of *tegong*: dedicated supplies for special occasions and routine *tegong*. The former applies mainly to the Beijing municipality and when the CCP provides *tegong* food for political events or conferences, such as meetings of the NPC and CPPCC, or for events such as the Olympic Games and state banquets. The latter concerns the provision of healthy everyday food by government agencies for cadres at specific administrative levels. The operation of both categories indicates that the *tegong* system is indeed meant to serve members of an elite class or designated groups. The secrecy surrounding this subject prevents the outside world from gaining a better understanding of this system.

Last, by ensuring food safety exclusively for a privileged class, the *tegong* system has exacerbated social inequality. A tight benefits chain has been formed between government agencies and food enterprises, leading to a close alliance relationship between the two parties. Government agencies provide covert monetary subsidies and administrative support, official endorsements, and trademarks for food enterprises, encouraging them to provide *tegong* at low prices. However, these practices can result in collusion between government and business and the marketing of fake *tegong* products. Another issue is that the general population does not have easy access to cheap healthy food. This finding supports the argument put forward by some scholars that in the process of economic transformation, the privileged class in socialist countries will make use of their existing political advantages and resources to ensure the persistence of their power and their positions. In these circumstances, the introduction of a market economy will not bring about a significant improvement in social equality.³⁰

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³⁰See Rona-Tas (1994) and Walder (1995).

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